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TECHNOLOGIES

BUYER'S GUIDE

Custom Software Pricing Guide — India 2026

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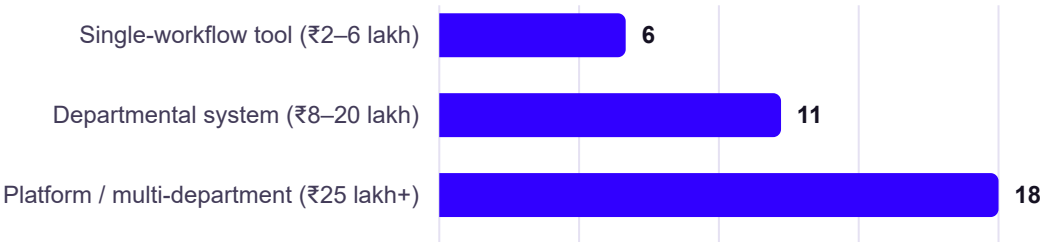
Summary

What drives a ₹2–6 lakh build versus ₹8–20 lakh and beyond, the three variables that actually move the price, typical timelines per band, and the questions to ask any vendor before signing. Written for owners and CFOs, not engineers.

- Three pricing bands with what fits in each, typical timelines and what is always included
- The three variables that drive cost: user roles, integrations and genuinely custom workflow
- A fixed-bid vs dedicated-team decision framework and the hybrid most SMEs should choose
- Six vendor questions that separate a delivery partner from a body shop

Typical first-release timeline by pricing band, weeks

Values in weeks



Single-workflow tool (₹2–6 lakh)	6 weeks
Departmental system (₹8–20 lakh)	11 weeks
Platform / multi-department (₹25 lakh+)	18 weeks

Why quotes for the same app differ tenfold

Ask five vendors what a custom CRM costs and you will get five answers between ₹2 lakh and ₹2 crore. Everyone is quoting honestly; they are quoting different things. The price is driven by three variables: how many distinct user roles need different screens, how many external systems must be integrated, and how much of the workflow is genuinely custom versus standard. Screen count is almost irrelevant.

The three bands

₹2–6 lakh · Single-workflow tool	One workflow, one admin role, no integrations	4–8 weeks
₹8–20 lakh · Departmental system	CRM / ERP / HRMS, 2–5 roles, 1–3 integrations	8–14 weeks
₹25 lakh+ · Platform	Multi-department, customer-facing apps, audit requirements	3–6+ months

What is always included

- A written scope before any code, and a thin-slice prototype by week three
- Code, repositories and credentials in your ownership from day one
- NDA and IP assignment signed before work starts
- A 24-hour response SLA written into the contract
- Clean exit rights at any point, with a documented handover

Fixed-bid or dedicated team

Fixed-bid works when the scope is genuinely defined and you are buying execution. A dedicated team works when the product is still being discovered and you are buying capacity. Running discovery work on a fixed bid produces padded prices or change-request fights. The hybrid we recommend most: a fixed-bid first phase that puts a thin slice in production, followed by a dedicated team working from a prioritised backlog.

Six questions to ask any vendor

- Can I see software this team has shipped — live links, not a portfolio?
- Who reviews the code, by name?
- What happens if an engineer resigns or underperforms — is replacement guaranteed in writing?
- Who owns the repositories from day one?
- What is the notice period to scale or pause?
- What happens in week one — is there a documented onboarding?

Budget for year two

Plan 15–20% of the build cost per year for hosting, maintenance and small improvements. Software is a living system; the cheapest project is the one that is still worth using in year three.